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Gods and goods in Africa

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It is clear that the Dukawa and Kamberi languages are closely related. In fact, so closely related are they that Gunn and Conant (1960) mistakenly identify them as mutually intelligible. What was said above (pp. 33-34) regarding the origin of the Kamberi is pertinent to that of the Dukawa. The Dukawa and Kamberi, in fact, have maintained a joking relationship with one another, stressing their traditional friendship and based on a common legend. As one would expect, the punch line of the legend varies, depending on the ethnic affiliation of the narrator.¹⁰

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Material Not Relevant

The main area of Dukawa habitation within Yauri was Rijau  -41- District, since 1923 part of Kontagora Emirate. Rijau was the extreme northeastern part of the Emirate. Within the district, the Dukawa had two major towns, Dukku (from whence their name) and Iri (Mahdi 1968:33: Prazan n.d.:1; NANK:K6099, Vols. I and II). Every Dukawa claims descent from one of these two towns, which seem to have been part of a defense system against endemic slave raids. The pressure of slave raids seems also to have caused at least some Dukawa to move to Shanga District, west of Rijau District, and since 1923 the easternmost extent of Yauri Emirate.

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Material Not Relevant

The story in its Dukawa version relates the incident of a Kamberi found buried in the ground by an enemy who had killed all the other Kamberi. The Kamberi at that time shaved all their hair. Thus, when the Dukawa tried to pull the man from the ground he could not. He waited patiently until enough hair grew on the Kamberi's head to enable him to yank him from the ground by the hair. To this day the Kamberi shave all their head except for a longish knot at the top. The Kamberi laugh at anyone who tells them the Dukawa version and claim that it was the Kamberi who saved the helpless Dukawa, and thus the Dukawa people.

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